



SERVICES PROVIDED

Architect

PROJECT TYPE

Office

LOCATION

Upper Hill, Nairobi, Kenya

YEAR

Completed in 1998

The Vice President for Citibank Real Estate presented a simple yet exacting brief, “A box with no columns” with an “International but also Kenyan” appearance.

As Architects, our main design challenges were:

- Citibank had already committed themselves to the site on Nairobi Hill for their new offices, in advance of selecting architects. This in itself presented several challenges which included: poor water, sewer, power and road services on Nairobi Hill, steep topography composed entirely of black trap rock, a very hard rock, difficult to quarry; and major road access compromises arising from security precautions from the adjacent British High Commission (under construction at the time).
- Reducing the accommodation to meet the strict budget. • Persuading Citibank Head Office in the USA that a fully air-conditioned building was not necessary.
- Minimizing excavation of rock and reusing the resulting rubble for landscaping, to reduce cartaway costs.
- Keeping columns to a minimum.
- Exploiting the excellent view over the city.
- Providing high levels of security whilst maintaining a “warm and welcome appearance”.

The atrium concept emerged with deep balcony work spaces looking into the naturally lit atrium and through the massive east-facing picture window overlooking the city. Columns were kept to a minimum by the 11 meter spanning beams.

A roof grid provides natural light into the Atrium whilst minimizing heat from the sun. The hand-worked aluminium entrance doors (hand-beaten by Samburu women and large bas relief sculptured panels provide the “Kenya” element. At the handing-over ceremony, Mr. Hands, Citibank’s Vicepresident for Real Estate stated; “You have not given me a box with no columns. You have given me a beautiful box with no columns”.